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CMCT 6535 Selected Topics in Technology in Practice: Digital Publication

Subject: Final Revised Web Text

Dear Rich,

Thank you for all of your suggestions throughout the term for the various iterations of my web text “The Musical Written on Air”. Please find below a summary of some changes I have made throughout the term and some of my thinking behind these changes.

Contribution

Incorporating the majority of the class’s suggestions, I added five paragraphs covering considerations in tone, issues with the conversation in the academic literature about *bacha bazi*, the gap that my work identifies, the wide audience of the essay, and future considerations in the conversation surrounding my topic. I decided to include these sections on the “index” page of the web text to serve as a sort of abstract with some sections, such as future directions, included with the full text on the “Essay” page.



“Index” pages of Iteration 1 (left) and Final Revised Iteration (right)

While editing the written text, I noticed an error in the categorization of discussion of the two authors, Charlie Sohne and Tim Rosser. Although Sohne would be described as a librettist as he wrote the book of the musical, Rosser would better be described as a composer having written the music for *The Boy Who Danced on Air*. With this consideration, I decided to change the title of my essay to “The Musical Written on Air” and reference to the authors as “writers” in the body of my essay. I also decided to add more section titles to the “Essay” page so that users could navigate the text heavy page more easily.

As the essay at times works with lyrical analysis and the problematic semiotics of the song “A Boy of My Own”, I countered Sohne and Rosser’s representation by including queered Afghan popular and folk songs in audio clips where I read my essay aloud. These songs include *Bache Khala* (My Aunt’s boy) by Mahdi Azad and the folk song *Bacha Jan Logari* (Dear Logari Boy) sung by Tajiki

Example of audio and captions on “Essay” page added to Final Revised Iteration

To incorporate Edward Tufte's interface model, I originally used Bootstrap's 12 column model to create marginal notes as opposed to Dave Liepmann's CSS itself. However, as I later wanted to add more content to the margins, I incorporated Liepmann's code to make the "Essay" page more uniform. I also borrowed Liepmann's "new thought" code for small caps introductions to each paragraph to signal a new idea.

Methodology

Adding archival material to both the essay and media pages, I used JavaScript to embed a lightbox for content pertaining to the musical and the 2020 backlash. Although the media page has limited content as Instagram files away some posts from its search, the pop-ups of comments from the community to Sohne and Rosser's apology and Hila Hamidi's activism help to illustrate the response of the Afghan community to the musical (both of which are found on the "Essay" page's marginal notes). Other archival material I included were accounts from survivors of *bacha bazi* found through Andrew Calimach and Samuel Vincent Jones' work. These stories juxtapose Sohne and Rosser's representation of victims and are placed strategically beside my conversations of their representation.

The screenshot displays a web page layout with a main content area on the left and a sidebar on the right. The main area has a light green background and contains two paragraphs of text. The first paragraph describes a mother and her son, Nuaman, being forced to leave their town after the death of the father, and the mother accepting help from men who offered to retrieve a van. The second paragraph, enclosed in a vertical box, is a quote from a survivor of *bacha bazi* describing sexual servitude. Below the quote, a sentence states that the horror described disrupts the lives of thousands of Afghan boys. The sidebar on the right has a pink background and lists several items: 'Introduction', 'On Position of Afghan's P', 'Video: Sohne and Rosser's Theatre O', 'Home(land)', 'The Boy V', 'Video: A Boy of My O', 'Stealing A', 'Video: Giu', 'Bacha ba', 'Bachagak', 'We Didn't', and 'Conclusion'.

"A mother and her twelve-year old son, Nuaman, were forced to leave their town after the death of Nuaman's father. During their journey, the mother accepted help from men who offered to retrieve a van for the two and drive them safely to their destination. Instead of transporting the two, Nuaman recalls that the men took him away from his mother and forced him into sexual servitude:

[T]hey kept me in a room for many days in [a place near Peshawar] where first they had sex with me by themselves for many days, and then they allowed everybody else to come and have sex with me for only 40-50 rupees. It was like I was an animal in the zoo, and people could see me and use me after paying the ticket fee. I was twelve and a half years old at that time. Within one month I think 20-30 men had sex with me and I was about to die of it.

The horror Nuaman describes disrupts the lives of potentially thousands of Afghan boys."

Introduction
On Position of Afghan's P
Video: Sohne and Rosser's Theatre O
Home(land)
The Boy V
Video: A Boy of My O
Stealing A
Video: Giu
Bacha ba
Bachagak
We Didn't
Conclusion

Example of a survivor's account of *bacha bazi* on "Essay" page added to Final Revised Iteration

Citations

I added citations from various authors into my conversation surrounding *bacha bazi* with consideration to race and the balance between open- and closed-access sources. However, I

couldn't determine any (dis)ability of authors. I also had some trouble finding female voices on the topic of *bacha bazi* in academic literature, however as the issue pertains to males it is valuable to have male insights. Some authors I included are Amalendu Misra, Andrew Calimach, Samuel Vincent Jones', and William Burmester as well as sources from social media. While Misra and Burmester's works are closed sources, Calimach's and Jones' works are open to the public. Although I didn't use some of these sources in the body of the written text, Jones' and Calimach's work was useful in providing individual accounts of *bacha bazi* and how the issue has affected survivors giving them a voice in the academic literature.

I very much enjoyed creating this web text for CMCT 6535 and value all of our group's insights and suggestions. It was useful to reengage with code after some years away and better understand how HTML, CSS, and JavaScript can add to the argument of a previously written work. Thank you to yourself and the class for the memorable journey.

Warmly,
Aly Husseinzadah